

this spectacle from their wooden stage, which suddenly resembles the platform of a gallows. They have been singing a comical song about death, which they stop as the penitents appear. Death spreads all around them, like the fog of incense spread by the monks, infecting and transforming everything in the frame. Many onlookers fall to their knees in prayer. It is a powerful, wordless metaphor for the human condition, blackly comic in its surreal grotesquery.

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Regardless of whether I believe or not, whether I am a Christian or not, I would play my part in the collective building of the cathedral.

Ingmar Bergman

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There are light touches of dark humor all over *The Seventh Seal*, and its final image is a cruel joke. “The master leads with scythe and hourglass,” says Jof, pointing to the horizon, where the Grim Reaper leads his latest victims—including the knight—in a *danse macabre* against the gray sky. “They move away from the dawn in a solemn dance, toward the dark country, while the rain washes over their faces and cleanses their cheeks of salt.”

Jof is mesmerized by the parade of the dead dancing beneath the darkening skies, but for some reason Mia cannot see the phantoms. She tuts affectionately at her husband. “You and your dreams and visions,” she smiles, and the two of them shake their heads, turn their backs on Death, and return to the business of living. ■

Death leads the dead in a dance that only Jof can see. The scene was improvised at the end of a day’s filming on the coast at Hovs Hallar, using crew members and a couple of passing tourists.



Ingmar Bergman Director

Born in Uppsala, Sweden, in 1918, Ingmar Bergman was the son of a Lutheran chaplain and was raised in a strict household. Invariably bleak, his movies deal with the major conflicts at the heart of human existence: madness versus sanity, death versus life, nothingness versus God. The human spirit rarely triumphs in these battles. *The Seventh Seal* was followed by *Wild Strawberries* and, later, a trilogy that explored the effects of human isolation: *Through a Glass Darkly*, *Winter Light*, and *The Silence*. His celebrated *Persona* was the first in a series inspired by Farö, a remote island in the Baltic Sea. Bergman died in 2007.

Key movies

1957 *The Seventh Seal*
1957 *Wild Strawberries*
1961 *Through a Glass Darkly*
1966 *Persona*

